

Interview Cartography

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Golden Idea

Here's every single kind of interview you'll face as well as a preparation checklist to ensure you're fully ready to perform at your best.

Importance

What's the main reason this idea is important to understand?

- You need to understand at a high-level what you're going to encounter & know how to prepare optimally to pass with flying colors.

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What Is An Interview?

In tech, an **interview** is any structured process used to evaluate a candidate's technical abilities and overall fit for a role after submitting their application. This process may include various assessments or discussions that test problem-solving skills, technical knowledge, and how well the candidate can handle job-specific challenges. Ultimately, the goal is to determine if the candidate has the right combination of skills, knowledge, and compatibility for the position and the company.

Hiring someone is a massive deal for a company, no matter what size — it's really a pain to hire, find out they're not a good fit, and then fire them. It drains these precious resources for the company:

- Opportunity Cost of not having someone doing a good job.
- Wasted team time training.
- Lost salary for a few months.
- Headache to fire someone legally.

The reason companies interview is because they don't want to just take your word for your skills — getting a hire right is very important, so they usually need to test your abilities.

Fundamentally, anyone can write anything on a resume. Also, there are some skills you just can't get from a resume — communication, delivery, culture fit, problem solving, etc.

We define the interview as any kind of evaluation that occurs after the application stage, beyond submission of personal details or information. Basically, anytime the company assesses you, whether it's a project, exam, live interview, we call that an interview or part of the interview stage.



Luck Is Reduced

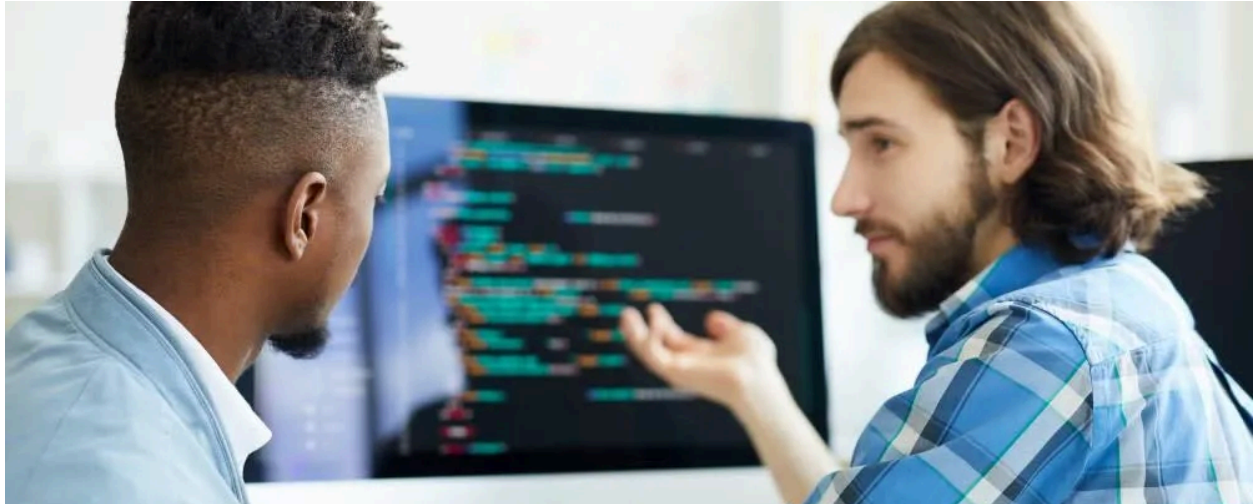
When you get to the interview stage, the luck in the process is greatly reduced compared to the application stage. If you're outstanding, it doesn't matter what school or background you have — you have a great shot of moving forward and getting that offer.

- Resume & Experience still matters because it breaks ties — but fundamentally, companies will rather hire someone who does better in the interview but has a worse resume over someone with a good resume and worse interview performance.

Luck can still play a part — some people have good interview days, might get a question they've seen before, but it really fundamentally is in your hands. You have the power to do well, and it's largely based on your skills and abilities.

It's much harder to fake interview skills — you can either solve the problem or not, and it's not based off of privilege, parents, anything like that. No matter what school you come from you can learn to do this.

The ball is now in your court, **so it's time to seize control and do incredible.**



Tech Interview Timeline & Structure

Here's how interviews are structured and all the kinds of interviews you might receive when going for a software engineering job or internship.

- In terms of timeline, expect 1-3 weeks of waiting to schedule each round — that's what normally happens. The interview might take 4-8 weeks after application — that's also normal. But this can vary wildly so take it with a grain of salt.
- These also might be combined together — you might have some behavioral questions followed up by a coding interview.

We will dive deep into each of these in future modules — these are just high level definitions.

1. Online Assessment

An **online assessment** (OA) in tech is a timed evaluation where candidates complete coding challenges or technical tasks. It tests problem-solving abilities, coding proficiency, and technical knowledge under pressure.

- Employers use these assessments to quickly and efficiently gauge a candidate's ability to handle real-world tasks relevant to the role before advancing them to further interview stages.
- **HackerRank & CodeSignal** are the most common platforms.

These are often the first or second round — they're used to filter out people who can't solve Data Structures & Algorithms problems and don't have great coding skills. They are usually Easy-Medium LeetCode problems.

Bigger companies use them more than smaller ones, and the more competitive the role the harder the questions. Quant roles notoriously have unbelievably difficult OAs.

You most likely will not escape these, especially if you're going for name-brand or FAANG roles — nearly every single competitive company has an OA. So you should just lean into them rather than being afraid.

2. Behavioral Interview

A **behavioral interview** is a conversation where candidates are asked about their past experiences, challenges, and work habits to assess soft skills like communication, teamwork, and problem-solving in real-world scenarios.

These interviews help employers evaluate how well a candidate can collaborate with others, adapt to challenges, and fit within the company's culture, complementing the technical skills evaluated in other stages of the interview process.

- Series of questions — usually 2-4 of them, with 2-5 min responses each.
 - “Tell me about yourself.”
 - “Why do you want to work at this company?”
 - “Tell me about a time where you had to learn a new language or framework to accomplish a goal.”

These are very important, and most people really underemphasize how integral they are to the process — in fact, every single company has behavioral interviews. You will do them for every role.

- Some companies ONLY do behavioral — that's how important it is.

3. Coding Interview

A **coding interview** is a live technical evaluation with a software engineer where candidates are asked to solve programming problems in real-time, often focusing on algorithms, data structures, and problem-solving.

- Typically conducted on a whiteboard, shared document, or coding platform, it assesses the candidate's coding proficiency, logical thinking, and ability to write efficient and clean code under pressure.

- At a high level, this is where a software engineer will give you 1 or 2 problems and ask you to solve them in front of them — you'll have around 25 mins per problem.
- Usually LeetCode mediums.
- Three Versions — DSA vs System Design vs OOP.
 - General Computer Science Concepts (Encapsulation, Abstraction, Inheritance, Databases, Operating Systems, etc.)

The above three are the bread and butter of interviewing — the 80/20 of landing a software engineering job. If you are great at OAs, behavioral interviews, and coding interviews, you're largely good.

4. Take-Home Project

A **take-home project** is an assessment where candidates are given a real-world task or coding challenge to complete over a few days and submit before the interview.

- This evaluation allows candidates to showcase their skills in a more flexible, non-timed environment, testing their ability to solve problems, write maintainable code, and think through larger-scale tasks, similar to what they would do in the actual role.
- Submit your GitHub repo of the finished project.

These are nice, but less common because they require more work on the company's behalf.

5. Work Simulation Assessment

A **work simulation assessment** is an evaluation where candidates are presented with business scenarios, case studies, or personality-based questions to assess how they would handle real-world work situations.

These tests often focus on decision-making, problem-solving, and alignment with company values and work styles, giving employers insight into how candidates might perform in the role and fit within the organizational culture. Examples include business simulations, work style assessments, and case study challenges.

Examples:

- **Amazon:**
 - Work Style Assessment
 - This assessment is designed to evaluate how well a candidate's work preferences align with Amazon's Leadership Principles. It's a personality-style test that measures traits like decision-making, teamwork, and adaptability.
- **Google:**
 - Googleyness and Leadership Interview
 - This component evaluates how a candidate fits within Google's culture and values. While not a formal personality test, it assesses collaboration, leadership, and problem-solving abilities through behavioral questions and hypothetical scenarios.
- **Microsoft:**
 - Situational Judgment Test (SJT)
 - Microsoft's SJT presents candidates with various workplace scenarios and asks them to choose how they would respond. The test assesses decision-making, communication, and teamwork skills.

6. Super Day / Onsite Interview / Panel Interview

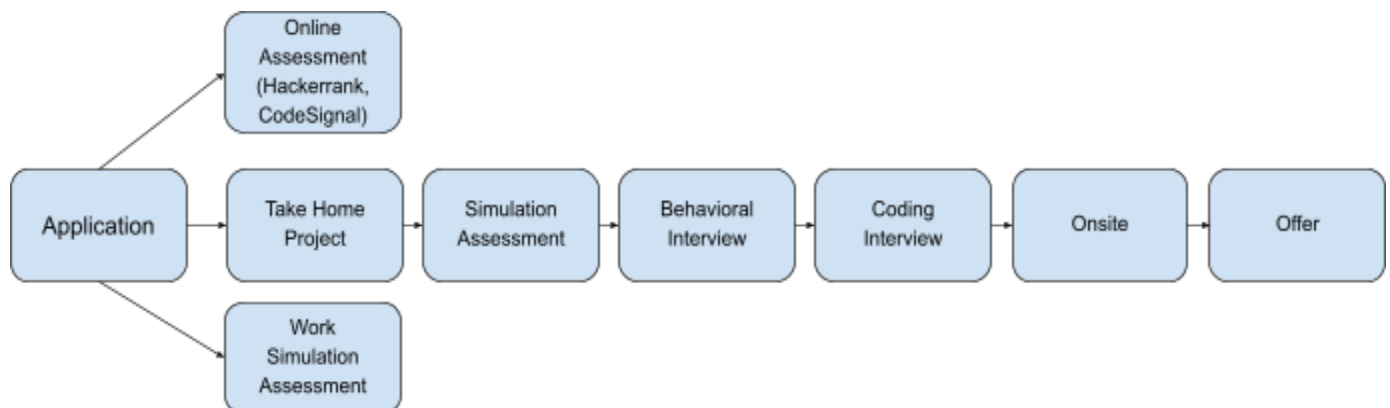
A **Super Day** or **Onsite Interview** is the final stage of the hiring process, where candidates undergo a series of back-to-back interviews, typically conducted virtually (used to be in-person pre-COVID).

This day-long or multi-hour session includes a combination of technical interviews, behavioral interviews, and possibly situational assessments or system design challenges. The goal is to evaluate the candidate's skills, problem-solving ability, and cultural fit in a comprehensive, real-time setting.



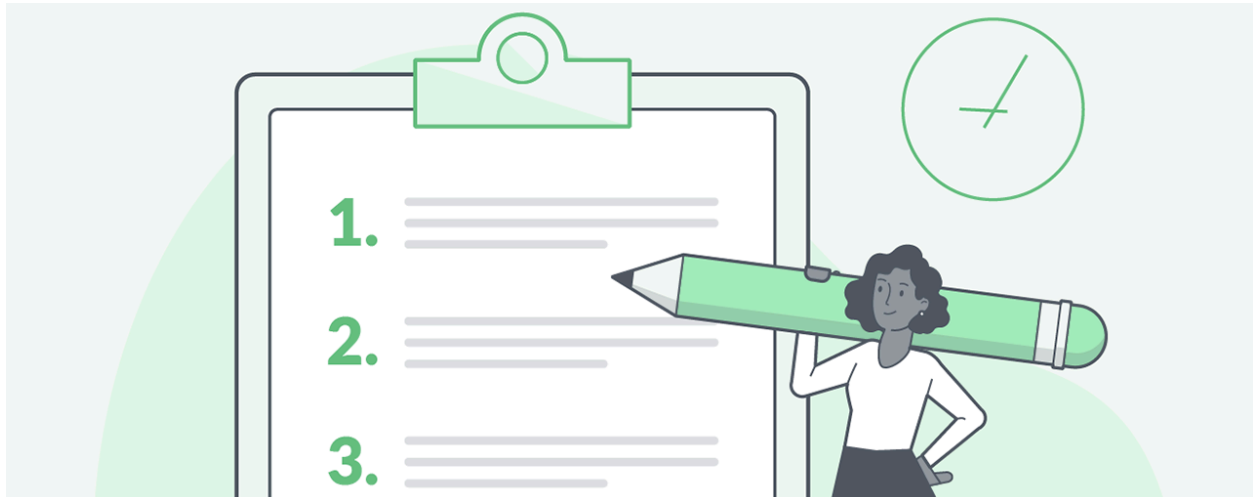
Full Sequence

- Every company is different, but here's an example of a very common flow of interviews for internships or new grad roles just so you have an idea.



When To Schedule An Interview

- Whenever you have a live interview, the company will nearly always send you a series of options and have you pick one or provide your availability.
- Here's a pro tip on scheduling — based on the window they give you, **schedule at the 40-50% mark.**
 - That gives you enough time to prepare, but also you don't want to go too far out — very often, these companies fill their positions on a rolling basis, so you don't want all the spots to be taken before your interview.



💡 Preparation Checklist For An Interview

Now that you know what kinds of interviews you might get & that over-preparation is key (given that we just need 1 offer to land), [here's a checklist of how to optimally prepare for interviews in general.](#)

- Based on the kind of interview, we will also later give you specifics on different techniques — but here are some general principles.

Through this process, you're building a report — it's almost as if you're doing an analysis on the company's interview process for a study or something.

- [Accompanying Worksheet](#) — this is going to give you the space to analyze the company's interview process using the following steps. You're required to fill this out and submit it at least three times over the next year (for three companies), but we recommend doing it every time you have an interview — when you do land an interview & fill it out, submit it at that point.

1. Do An Informational Interview

An **informational interview** is a casual, non-evaluative conversation where a person (usually a job seeker or someone exploring a career change) meets with a professional to learn about their career path, industry, or company.

- The purpose is to gather insights, advice, and information, not to apply for a job or be formally assessed. It's a networking tool often used to explore potential opportunities and make connections in a specific field.

- You'll want to find at least one (ideally 2-3) people who have passed all interviews at the company you're interviewing for and get on a call / have a conversation with them. Why?
 - They've passed the interview, so they know what you'll encounter and can coach you on how to prepare.
 - 1. I did this for Shopify and it worked wonders.
 - They have context on the company and what the company cares about in general. They can teach you about the product, values, mission, and culture — and that knowledge is unbelievably important for passing an interview. Companies drill their employees on what they care about, so this will get you very far ahead.
 - Do this using our **LinkedIn Networking Strategy** from Get The Interview. Rewatch *Networking 101*.
 - If you can't find someone who interned or worked at the company you're going for, then do it with someone who at least did the interview process.
- Questions To Ask:
 - 1. *"Can you walk me through what the interview process was like for you when you applied? What stages stood out the most, and how did you prepare for them?"*
 - 2. *"What specific skills or knowledge do you think are most important for succeeding in the technical interviews at this company?"*
 - 3. *"Are there any common mistakes or misconceptions that you see candidates make during the interview process?"*
 - 4. *"How would you recommend approaching the behavioral or cultural fit aspects of the interview, and what traits do they seem to value most?"*
 - 5. *"Are there any resources you'd recommend I use to prepare or any other people you know who I can talk to about how to take on this process?"*
- You'll want to dig deep here — ask them extremely specific questions about their responses, and make sure you fully understand.

2. Internet Deep Dive

Next, you're going to do a full internet deep dive on the interview process.

- You'll search this (and other variations): "[company name] [interview stage] [role]", ex. Amazon Online Assessment Software Engineering Internship
- Read through Reddit, Glassdoor, Quora, Blind, etc.
- Do a full search and read everything you can find — you'll be surprised on how much you can learn. Spend about 30-60 minutes doing this and filling out the accompanying worksheet with everything you can learn about the interview.

3. Do Tons of Practice

The final stage of preparing for an interview — once you know what's on it, you do tons and tons of company-specific practice.

We will cover this in great detail in the later modules (specifically what to practice based on what kind of interview it is), but the important idea is to do what is on the interview.

- **Example.** if it's behavioral, find out what questions they ask, and drill those 10 times until you're absolutely perfect. ex. if it's coding, then do all the tagged LeetCode questions until you know the top 30 of them completely by heart.

Why? There are several reasons.

- **Context-Dependent Memory:** Research shows that people recall information better when they are in an environment similar to where they originally learned it. By simulating the real conditions of an interview or competition, you create mental associations that improve recall and performance under pressure.
- **Stress Inoculation:** Exposing yourself to challenging or stressful environments repeatedly helps build resilience and reduce anxiety. This is known as **stress inoculation**—you become more accustomed to handling pressure, which lowers the emotional impact in real situations and improves performance.
- **Performance Under Pressure: Yerkes-Dodson Law** states that a moderate level of stress or arousal improves performance. Practicing under realistic pressure conditions trains your body and mind to perform well despite stress, making the actual event feel familiar and manageable.
- **Skill Transfer:** By practicing in an environment as close to the real thing as possible, you enhance **skill transfer**—the ability to apply what you've learned in practice to the actual event. Replicating real-world challenges ensures your brain adapts to those conditions.

This is another reason why we do live mock interviews in this program — to simulate the real experience so you know exactly what to do on game day.